

LINEUP DECISIONS

WHY 80% IS MENTAL



MOST CLUB ATHLETES CAN PHYSICALLY DO THE JOB. THAT'S NOT WHAT DETERMINES THE LINEUP.

THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Why 80% Is Mental

← You are here

02

What Coaches Actually Watch For

Coming up.

03

The Pressure Performance Gap

Coming up.

04

Training the Mental Game

Coming up.

05

Showing Up When It Counts

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

ON A CLUB TEAM,
MOST ATHLETES CAN
PHYSICALLY DO THE JOB.
THE ONES WHO PLAY
ARE THE ONES WHO
CAN DO IT UNDER PRESSURE.

That's the difference. And that's what 80/20 means not that mechanics don't matter, but that emotional control is the separator.

— PHYSICAL SKILL GETS YOU IN THE ROOM. MENTAL SKILL KEEPS YOU THERE.

THE 80/20 RULE

THE GAME IS 80%
MENTAL AND 20%
PHYSICAL.

→ At the club level: most athletes have comparable physical skills

→ The separator: who can access those skills when it's game point, after a mistake, mid-run

→ Pressure doesn't create problems it reveals the mental game that was or wasn't built

— IF YOU CAN'T ACCESS IT UNDER PRESSURE, YOU DON'T HAVE IT YET.

05 · WHAT COACHES ARE WATCHING

THE MENTAL GAME INDICATORS

POST-MISTAKE RESET

How long does she take to get mentally back after an error? Speed here is a skill.

PRESSURE CONSISTENCY

Does she perform the same in a close set as she does when the game is out of reach?

DECISION SPEED

Can she read the play and commit without hesitation in game-point moments?



06 · FOR YOUR ATHLETE

WHAT THIS MEANS PRACTICALLY

THE WORK ISN'T JUST PHYSICAL

Every rep of emotional regulation, every reset practice, every moment of pressure management is training.



THE ANSWER IS IN PRACTICE

Pressure performance in matches reflects pressure habits built at practice.

START NOW

Mental game development is trainable but only if it's being trained.

07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

YOUR COACH KNOWS
YOU HAVE THE SKILL.
SO DOES THE OTHER
TEAM'S COACH.
WHAT SEPARATES YOU
IS WHETHER YOU
CAN USE IT WHEN
IT COUNTS.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE MENTAL GAME IS THE GAME

THIS WEEK

IDENTIFY THE MENTAL GAME GAP THIS WEEK

✓ Watch your athlete closely in the next competition specifically in high-pressure moments.

✓ How long is her post-mistake reset? Is it improving?

✓ Does her performance change when the score is close vs. comfortable?

✓ Name one specific mental skill to train starting this week.



LINEUP DECISIONS

WHAT COACHES
ACTUALLY WATCH FOR

02

THE COACH'S CHECKLIST IS NOT WHAT MOST PARENTS THINK IT IS.

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THE COACH ISN'T
WATCHING THE SKILL.
SHE ALREADY KNOWS
YOUR ATHLETE HAS IT.
SHE'S WATCHING
WHAT HAPPENS AFTER
A MISTAKE.

Post-mistake behavior is the most honest data point a coach has. Everything else can be performed. The reset is real.

— THE RESET IS THE REAL SKILL

THE COACH'S CHECKLIST

AFTER A MISTAKE: WHAT DOES SHE DO?

→ Does she look to the stands, look down, or look to the next play?

→ Does she visibly tighten or does she stay loose and ready?

→ Does she ask for help or does she self-correct?

— THE ATHLETE WHO RESETS FASTEST PLAYS THE MOST.

05 · THE FOUR SIGNALS COACHES TRACK

GAME - POINT BEHAVIOR

EYES

Where do they go after a mistake? Stands = external. Down = shame spiral. Next play = ready.

BODY LANGUAGE

Does the mistake live in her shoulders for the next three points? Coaches see it.

DECISION SPEED

Does she hesitate more in the next high-stakes moment? Or does she trust herself?



06 · BUILDING THE RESET

HOW TO TRAIN IT

NAME IT

Give the reset a physical cue: a word, a breath, a step. Something that interrupts the spiral.

DRILL IT

In practice, create pressure scenarios and practice the reset not just the skill.

MAKE IT AUTOMATIC

Like any technical skill: it has to be trained so many times that it shows up without thinking.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

THE RESET AFTER
A MISTAKE IS A SKILL.
TRAIN IT AT PRACTICE
SO IT SHOWS UP
WHEN IT MATTERS.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— TRAIN THE RESET

THIS WEEK

BUILD A RESET PROTOCOL THIS WEEK.

✓ Help your athlete design a personal reset cue: a word, a breath, a physical movement.

✓ Practice it off the court so it's accessible when the pressure arrives.

✓ At the next competition, watch specifically for the reset not the skill.

✓ Debrief: how fast was the reset? What made it faster or slower?



LINEUP DECISIONS

THE PRESSURE PERFORMANCE GAP

03

PRACTICE PERFORMANCE AND MATCH PERFORMANCE TELL TWO DIFFERENT STORIES.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

SHE PLAYS GREAT
AT PRACTICE.
SOMETHING HAPPENS
IN THE MATCH.
THAT GAP IS NOT
A SKILL PROBLEM.

The practice-match performance gap is one of the most common things coaches see and it's entirely addressable through mental game training.

— THE GAP IS THE MENTAL GAME

WHY THE GAP EXISTS

PRACTICE SAFETY VS. COMPETITION STAKES.

- Practice: low stakes, familiar environment, room to experiment
- Competition: perceived judgment, playing time implications, emotional activation
- The gap: the nervous system hasn't been trained to perform in both environments

— PRACTICE THE PRESSURE. NOT JUST THE SKILL.

05 · WHAT CREATES THE GAP

THREE CAUSES

FEAR OF MISTAKES

In competition, mistakes feel permanent. In practice, they're just reps. This fear tightens execution.



EXTERNAL JUDGMENT

The parent in the stands, the coach's expression, teammates' reactions she's managing all of it live.

STAKES ACTIVATION

Her nervous system reads competition as a threat. Skills trained in a safe environment don't transfer cleanly.



06 · CLOSING THE GAP

P R E S S U R E T R A I N I N G

CREATE PRESSURE AT PRACTICE

Games within practice, consequences for errors, performance with an audience.

DEBRIEF PERFORMANCE, NOT RESULTS

After competition: 'how did your mental game perform?' not 'what was the score?'

CELEBRATE PRESSURE MOMENTS

When she performs well in a high-pressure moment name it. Build the identity around it.

02



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE ATHLETE WHO
TRAINED HER MENTAL GAME
WILL OUTPERFORM THE ONE
WHO ONLY TRAINED
HER SKILLS.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— CLOSE THE GAP THROUGH TRAINING

THIS WEEK

TRAIN FOR PRESSURE THIS WEEK.

- ✓ Ask her coach if practice can include one pressure scenario per session.
- ✓ After the next competition, debrief specifically about mental performance not results.
- ✓ Name one high-pressure moment where she performed well and celebrate it explicitly.
- ✓ Identify what she did mentally in that moment that she can replicate.



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TRAINING THE MENTAL GAME



MENTAL SKILLS ARE TRAINABLE. THEY JUST REQUIRE INTENTIONAL PRACTICE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE MENTAL GAME
ISN'T A PERSONALITY
TRAIT.
IT'S A SKILL.
AND SKILLS ARE TRAINED.

Every athlete has the capacity to develop emotional regulation, decision speed, and pressure tolerance. Most never train for it intentionally.

— TRAIN IT LIKE A TECHNICAL SKILL

THE MENTAL SKILL TOOLKIT

FIVE SKILLS. ALL TRAINABLE.

- Reset speed: how fast after a mistake you're ready for the next play
- Pressure tolerance: the ability to perform under elevated stakes without tightening
- Decision confidence: trusting the instinct without second-guessing in real time

— INTENTION TURNS PRACTICE INTO MENTAL TRAINING.

05 · DAILY TRAINING HABITS

WHAT TO ADD

PRE-PRACTICE INTENTION

Before every practice: name one mental skill to focus on. Not volleyball mental.



THE PRESSURE REP

At least one rep per practice should be done under self-created pressure.

POST-PRACTICE DEBRIEF

One question: how did my mental game perform today?



06 · THE LONG VIEW

WHAT CHANGES OVER A SEASON

RESET SPEED INCREASES

The gap between mistake and readiness shrinks from 3 plays to 1.

PRESSURE BECOMES NEUTRAL

What once activated the threat response becomes just another moment.

COACHES NOTICE

The pattern shifts. The file updates. The opportunity expands.

02

07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

THE MENTAL GAME
THAT SHOWS UP IN
GAME POINT DIDN'T
ARRIVED THAT DAY.
IT WAS BUILT IN
HUNDREDS OF REPS
OF INTENTIONAL TRAINING.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— TRAIN IT LIKE A SKILL

THIS WEEK

ADD ONE MENTAL SKILL TO TRAINING THIS WEEK

- ✓ Name one mental skill to focus on this week: reset speed, pressure tolerance, or decision confidence.
- ✓ Before each practice this week, set an intention for that skill specifically.
- ✓ After each practice, rate the skill on a 1–10 scale. Track it for 5 days.
- ✓ At the end of the week: what did you notice? Is it getting more accessible?



LINEUP DECISIONS

SHOWING UP
WHEN IT COUNTS

OS

THE GAME-POINT MOMENT REVEALS THE SEASON'S MENTAL TRAINING.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE GAME-POINT MOMENT
DOESN'T CREATE
ANYTHING NEW.
IT REVEALS WHAT
WAS ALREADY THERE.

Everything she built every reset rep, every pressure drill, every intentional debrief is what shows up when it matters most.

— GAME POINT IS THE REPORT CARD

THE CULMINATION

THE SEASON'S MENTAL TRAINING LIVES HERE.

- Game-point performance is a direct reflection of mental game habits built in practice
- The athlete who trained for this moment is not calm because she's not nervous she's calm because she prepared
- The reset is fast, the decision is trusted, the execution follows the training

— PREPARE FOR THE MOMENT BEFORE IT ARRIVES.

05 · THE MENTAL PRE-GAME

WHAT TO DO BEFORE GAME POINT

BREATHE AND NAME

Name the emotional state before the high-pressure moment: 'I'm nervous. That's okay. It means I care.'



USE THE RESET CUE

The physical cue built all season use it before the moment, not just after mistakes.

TRUST THE TRAINING

The moment is not the time to think. It's the time to trust what the body already knows.



06 · AFTER THE SEASON

BUILDING TOWARD NEXT YEAR

REVIEW THE MENTAL GAME

At season end: where did the mental game improve most? Where is the biggest remaining gap?

NAME THE WINS

She performed in a high-pressure moment this season. Name it. Make it part of her story.

SET THE NEXT INTENTION

What specific mental skill is the focus for next season?



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

GAME POINT IS
NOT THE TIME
TO FIND YOUR MENTAL GAME.
IT'S THE TIME
TO USE THE ONE
YOU ALREADY BUILT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— PREPARE FOR THE MOMENT

THIS WEEK

CLOSE THE SEASON WITH A MENTAL GAME REVIEW.

✓ Name three moments this season where the mental game showed up under pressure.

✓ Name the one moment it failed and what it revealed about the next skill to build.

✓ Review the reset speed: how has it changed from the beginning of the season to now?

✓ Set one mental skill intention for next season before tryouts begin.

